with Massoud and Rabbani (on Srinivasan's orders). Just like his R&AW counterparts, he received detailed insights into the newly emerged militia from Massoud.[105] On his return to Delhi, Bhadrakumar advised the leadership to not offer military support to any side given the fluidity of alliances on the ground.

Within two days of coming to power in Kabul, the Taliban (which was no longer small) lynched India's former ally Najibullah and hung his body (with that of his brother) in central Kabul.[106] Najibullah was shot in the head and his beaten and bloated body was hung from a crane. Kabul's fall and Najibullah's gruesome murder came as a shock to New Delhi (and the world). In keeping with international reaction, India's official policy was unambiguously opposed to the Taliban's political and social conduct. This opposition had four key aspects. Firstly, New Delhi closed its embassy in Kabul and evacuated its personnel citing safety concerns. As with most other countries, India had no diplomatic presence in Kabul throughout the period of Taliban rule from 1996 until 2001. Based on this absence, Indian officials and analysts conclude that India had 'no contacts with the Pashtuns' during these six years.[107] Secondly, it endorsed the UNSC Resolution 1076 which criticised the Taliban for violating human and women's rights, and decided not to recognise the regime as Afghanistan's legitimate government.[108] Existing literature treats this phase of India-Afghanistan relations as a diplomatic black hole without much substance to the relationship. Moreover, India's anti-Taliban stance has been assessed as strategically sound and politically correct by former Indian officials.[109] This is because of the Taliban's ideological make-up and perceived anti-India stance. Thirdly, India maintained diplomatic links with the internationally recognised Rabbani government and hosted Massoud Khalili, Rabbani's political aide, as its ambassador to New Delhi. Khalili was constantly in touch with the Indian government and lobbied for the latter's support against the Taliban.[110] Finally, India provided covert military, financial, and medical support to the anti-Taliban United Front (UF) in coalition with Russia, Iran, and the Central Asian Republics (CARs).

India's material support to the UF is an open secret. Based on interviews with India's intelligence and diplomatic officials, declassified US intelligence dossiers, as well as existing media reports, it can be confirmed that India clandestinely gave the UF material (and not just moral and diplomatic) support.[111] This was done